

American Politics August 2025 General Exam

Instructions: Please answer 3 questions, making sure to answer at least one question from Part 1 and Part 2. Please read the questions carefully and make sure you answer all the parts of the questions you chose.

The exam is open book and open note. You are free to consult original source material, but not to consult another live person or to use AI/ChatGPT/etc.

Once you begin the exam, you have 8 hours to complete the exam.

Part 1.

1. Scholars debate whether mass polarization in the American electorate is primarily driven by issue-based ideological sorting or by social identity-based affective polarization. First, explain the theoretical distinctions between these two perspectives on polarization. Then, analyze how each framework would predict different patterns in voter behavior and political outcomes. Finally, evaluate the methodological challenges in distinguishing between these explanations empirically, and propose a research design that could help adjudicate between them.
2. Verba, Scholzman, and Brady (1995) argue that political participation in America is stratified by socioeconomic status, creating inequalities in who participates and whose voices are heard. First, pick and explain some of the distinct theoretical perspectives that scholars have used to explain patterns of political participation. Next, evaluate the empirical evidence regarding participatory inequality across different forms of political activity. Finally, assess the implications of these participatory patterns for democratic representation and policy outcomes in the United States. In your answer, be sure to address both behavioral and institutional factors that shape participation.
3. Enns (2015) points out that rich Americans and poor Americans tend to have similar levels of support for policies (see e.g., Figure 5 in his Perspectives on Politics article). This complicates studies of undue influence of the preferences of the rich. On the other hand, scholars of political behavior and psychology might warn us about taking such measures of public opinion literally. Explain the theoretical models and evidence that backs up this behavioralist's critique, and its implications, in your view, for the Enns debate. Be sure to explain and evaluate the evidence in at least one study concretely.
4. How did African American voters increase their influence in the Democratic Party from the Civil War to the present day? Give an account based on the political science literature that addresses the following aspects: (1) interest groups, (2) social movements, and (3) electoral power. Be specific in the literature you cite. Your response should engage with the arguments of Schickler (2016), citing specific findings and quotes where necessary, and extend to other relevant literature.

5. Achen and Bartels (2016) claim that “candidate choices determine [voter’s] issue positions, not vice versa.” This leads scholars to conclude that issues don’t matter in explaining the political behavior of American voters, instead emphasizing the role of party loyalty or group identity. First, explain why the debate is important. Next, provide 2-3 pieces of the strongest evidence on each side of this debate. Finally, where do you come down on the question of whether issues matter to American voters? Why?

6. Political spending of all forms (lobbying, campaign donations, investments in organization-building and grassroots mobilization, etc.) has risen dramatically in the last generation. Yet political scientists struggle to find conclusive evidence that these substantial investments yield substantive payoffs for the individuals and groups who make them. One potential conclusion is that such spending actually matters relatively little, whether because of diminishing returns or the offsetting effects of competing actors or the difficulty of affecting electoral or policy change itself. An alternative conclusion is that there are large payoffs for at least some kinds of investments but, for methodological reasons, political scientists have not been able to measure them. Where do you come down on this issue? In answering this question, please focus on a few policy areas or types of political activity and discuss and critique the empirical evidence. What kinds of data or analyses would allow us to adjudicate among these starkly competing interpretations?

Part 2

7. A first generation of studies of executive orders stressed the power of unilateral action. A second generation, however, showed that most executive orders were not promulgated unilaterally but collectively and that many were never implemented, blocked by either the bureaucracy or the courts. In light of the record number of executive orders issued at the opening of the second Trump administration, their policy reach, their implementation by administrators, and the response to them from the Court, do we need a third generation of studies? How specifically might such studies depart from prior thinking about unilateral action and the constitutional system of checks and balances?
8. American Progressivism was born as a movement to displace the party state of the nineteenth century with an administrative state, and for the first two-thirds of the twentieth century, progressivism was not a party affair. There were proponents and opponents of progressive reform in both of the major parties. However, after the “big sort” in party alliances that followed the rights revolution, progressivism found itself sequestered in one of the major parties with implacable opponents concentrated in the other. What are the consequences of this development for the progressive reform agenda? Has the creation of a de-facto “progressive party” served or impeded the program? Were the original Progressives correct that a polity sharply divided along partisan lines is incompatible with a robust administrative state? Why or why not?
9. A key organizational feature of the US House is legislative committees. In some theoretical accounts, these committees are powerful. What are the institutional sources of committee power and how is it exercised? What is the evidence that substantiates the thesis that committees are powerful? Your answer should clearly define what is meant by “power” (vis-à-vis whom?) and be specific about institutional features that lead to that power.
10. In a simplified account of lawmaking, Congress passes a bill that the President then vetoes or accepts. In a simple unidimensional spatial model of lawmaking, assume that the House and Senate are both controlled by the left political party while the presidency is controlled by the right party.
 - A. What are the expected political dynamics of policy change and outcomes in this setup? In constructing your answer, please characterize dynamics across different values of the current status quo policy. You may assume that all actors have utilities defined by $U_i(x) = -|X_i - x|$, where $U_i(x)$ is the utility to person i of policy x given their preferred policy is X_i .
 - B. Certain accounts argue that the president has key first mover advantages vis-à-vis the Congress to set policy (the status quo) ahead of Congressional action. How does that change expected political outcomes?

C. What does the difference between your answer to Part A and Part B tell us about the value of agenda setting?

11. Bawn (1995) notes that, “By delegating policy decisions to the bureaucracy, Congress creates a control problem for itself.” Why does Congress, and other political principals such as the President, create this problem for themselves, and what techniques do they have for addressing it?
12. Suppose you could go back in time and manipulate one historical event so that it turned out differently. If you wanted to test a key theoretical or empirical claim in Political Science, what event would you pick and why? What would you learn from observing this counterfactual? Your answer should specify how people interpret the event as realized and their assumptions about what is not observed.